per cent, the lowest in the country, with a revenue surplus of Rs 43,471 crore and zero market borrowing (see *A Progress Report*). Much of the increase has come from the change in policy in 2019 to not only receive royalties but also auction its mineral wealth that has seen revenues grow five-fold and fund Naveen's vast welfare programmes.

After his assembly election victory in 2019, Naveen came up with what he called 5T, which stood for Teamwork, Technology, Transparency and Time leading to Transformation, and chose Pandian, who was his private secretary then, to spearhead the effort. Shaken by the fact that the BJP had won eight of the state's 21 Lok Sabha seats and that its vote share now posed a serious threat to the BJD, he shrewdly began keeping vote banks in mind while devising the newer development and welfare schemes.

WOOING VOTE BANKS

Much of his development efforts thus came to be directed towards youth and women even as he worked on reducing overall poverty. To cater to the youth, he focused on improving education and sports facilities. So, apart from opening 315 Odisha Adarsha Vidyalayas that would impart education in the English medium, more than 8,500 schools were upgraded, with digital blackboards in high schools, improved classroom infrastructure and libraries, and toilets across government schools. That makeover is evident in the 171-year-old Puri Zilla School, which has 1,700 students and has seen its classrooms upgraded in the past two years with digital blackboards and enhanced sports facilities. The last includes a full-fledged training centre for gymnasts, where we find 12-year-old Bhumika Reddy doing the hoops with ease and saying she aspires to be an Olympic star.

Making Odisha a sports hub of the country, particularly for hockey and training, is one of Naveen's major accomplishments. The state now boasts of two world-class hockey stadiums in Bhubaneswar and Rourkela, which have come up in the past decade; Odisha has also hosted the Hockey World Cup twice in the past five years. Bhubaneswar's Kalinga Stadium has been transformed into a national sports training centre of repute with state-of-the-art equipment, including advanced computers and software to improve sportspersons' performance. "We realised that, to produce world champs,

KEY STRATEGIES

BJD

- Highlighting the developments achieved during Naveen Patnaik's regime
- Wooing 7 million women enrolled under the Mission Shakti SHG programme
- Targeting the middle-class with interest subvention offers on home loans and education loans besides 100 units of free power and healthcare coverage under BSKY
- Projecting the Centre as anti-Odisha highlighting its alleged stand against the formation of the Mahanadi tribunal to sort out water disputes with Chhattisgarh

BJP

- Targeting Pandian, a Tamilian, calling the shots, the BJP has successfully fanned the Odia vs non-Odia debate that has been going on in the state with Pandian's apparent ascension as Naveen's heir
- Fanning the controversy over the Shree Mandir Parikrama Prakalpa
- Promising to introduce a 'Zero Tolerance' policy against corruption
- Promising Subhadra Yojana, under which every woman will receive a cash voucher of Rs 50,000 to be encashed over two years
- Engineering defections within the BJD





RAJ CHENGAPPA